The First Customer Playbook for AI Builders

A Practical Guide to Finding Prospects, Starting Conversations, and Pursuing Your First Paying Customer

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Introduction: You Built It. Now Find a Buyer.

You have a working product. It might be an AI app you assembled over a few weekends with Claude Code, Cursor, Lovable, Bolt, Replit, or a similar tool. It runs. It does something useful. You may have launched it somewhere.

And nobody has paid for it.

If that describes you, you are in a very common place. Modern tools have made building far easier than it used to be. They have not made it easier to find the right person, earn their attention, and learn whether they would pay. Those are different skills, and nobody gets them automatically from being good at building.

A working product is not proof of demand

A product that works proves one thing: you can build it. Demand is a separate question: do specific people have a problem they care enough about to spend money or time to solve, and would your product be the way they solve it?

You cannot answer that from your laptop. Only conversations with the people who have the problem can answer it.

Why more features is usually the wrong next step

When a product gets no customers, the instinct is to build more. It feels productive, it is within your control, and it avoids the uncomfortable thing, which is talking to strangers.

But if you don't know who your customer is, you can't know which features matter. You end up guessing, and each guess costs days of work. Building more before learning more often means building a larger version of something nobody has asked for.

This does not mean the product never needs work. It means you should let evidence from buyers tell you what to build next, rather than your own assumptions.

What this book does

This book gives you a process for the work between "it's built" and "someone paid":

1. Choose a narrow customer and a specific problem.
2. Find real people who plausibly have that problem, and record why you think so.
3. Look for evidence the problem matters to them.
4. Start respectful, relevant conversations.
5. Learn from those conversations before you pitch.
6. Turn your app into a clear offer.
7. Demo it, handle objections, and ask directly.
8. Follow up professionally and learn from every outcome.
9. Run all of it as a seven-day sprint, then repeat.

What this book does not do

It does not promise a customer. Some people who follow this process will find a buyer quickly, some slowly, and some will learn that their current idea needs a different audience, offer, or direction. All three outcomes are useful, because each tells you something real.

It also does not teach you to code, run ads, or grow an audience. It is about one job: finding and pursuing your first customers for a product that already exists.

How to use this book

Read one chapter, do its exercises, and then move on. The appendices are reusable worksheets, scripts, and templates. If you want to go fast, read Chapters 1 through 3 and then jump to Chapter 9 and run the sprint, using the other chapters as reference.

Three running examples

To keep things concrete, three hypothetical products appear throughout. None of them is real.

- **ClipNotes** (a creator tool): an AI app that turns a podcast episode recording into show notes, chapter timestamps, and a short summary. Built by a hypothetical founder, Maya.
- **QuoteFlow** (a business workflow tool): an AI app that turns a contractor's rough job notes into a clean, itemized estimate document. Built by a hypothetical founder, Dev.
- **ReviewReply** (a small SaaS product): an AI app that drafts replies to online reviews for independent coffee shops and small restaurants, for the owner to approve before posting. Built by a hypothetical founder, Sam.

Whenever you see a conversation, prospect record, or outcome involving them, remember it is an illustration, not a real result.

Chapter 1: Choose a Specific Customer and Problem

Everything else in this book depends on this chapter. If you target the wrong people, even excellent outreach will fall flat. If you target a clear group with a clear problem, even clumsy outreach has a chance.

Why "everyone who uses AI" is not a target

"Anyone who wants to be more productive with AI" describes billions of people and tells you nothing. You can't answer the questions that matter:

- Where do these people spend time online?
- What words do they use to describe their problem?
- What are they doing about it today?
- Who would you message first?

A narrow target answers all four. "Solo podcasters who publish weekly and edit their own episodes" tells you where to look (podcasting communities), what they complain about (editing time, show notes), what they currently do (write notes by hand), and who to contact first.

Narrow does not mean small forever. It means a starting point. You are choosing where to begin learning, not where to stop.

Features versus problems

A **feature** is something your product does. A **problem** is something the customer experiences. Customers buy outcomes, so lead with the problem.

Feature (what it does)	Problem (what the customer experiences)
"Generates show notes with GPT-style summaries"	"I spend two hours after every episode writing show notes and I dread it."
"Converts text notes into PDF estimates"	"I do quotes at night after work and sometimes a quote goes out three days late."
"Drafts review replies in a brand voice"	"I know I should reply to reviews, but I never have time, and the angry ones stress me out."

The four-part definition

Before you contact anyone, write down these four things in plain language:

1. **Customer:** Who exactly is this person? (Role, situation, size, context.)
2. **Problem:** What are they struggling with, in their words?
3. **Current alternative:** What do they do today? (Including "nothing," a spreadsheet, a competitor, or a person.)
4. **Desired outcome:** What would "better" look like for them?

The current alternative is the one beginners skip. Your real competitor is rarely another app. It is usually a habit, a spreadsheet, an assistant, or doing nothing.

Assumptions versus evidence

An **assumption** is something you believe but haven't confirmed. **Evidence** is something you observed from outside your own head: a person saying it, a public post describing it, or behavior you can see.

"Podcasters hate writing show notes" is an assumption until you find podcasters saying so in their own words, or tell you in a conversation.

Mark each statement in your customer definition as **A** (assumption) or **E** (evidence). Most of your first draft will be A. That is normal. The rest of this book is about converting assumptions into evidence.

Customer selection exercise

Work through these steps on paper or in Appendix A.

Step 1: List who has used or could use your product. Write down every type of person you can think of. Aim for 8 to 15.

Step 2: Score each type from 1 (low) to 5 (high) on four questions:

- **Pain:** How likely is it that they feel this problem regularly?
- **Reachability:** Can I find and contact them directly, without a big budget?
- **Ability to pay:** Do they spend money on tools or services for problems like this?
- **Fit:** Does my product, as it exists today, solve their problem without major new work?

Step 3: Add the scores. Take the top three types.

Step 4: Pick one. Choose the one you can reach most easily this week. Where scores are close, choose the group you understand best or can reach fastest.

Step 5: Narrow it further. Add one or two qualifiers (size, frequency, tool they use, region, or situation) until you can imagine finding twenty specific people who match.

Step 6: Write the four-part definition and mark each part A or E.

Hypothetical examples

Example 1: Maya and ClipNotes (too broad, then narrowed)

Maya's first target: "content creators." She narrowed it step by step:

- Content creators → podcasters
- Podcasters → independent podcasters who produce their show themselves
- Independent podcasters → those who publish at least weekly and include written show notes on their site

Four-part definition:

- **Customer:** Solo podcasters who publish weekly and write their own show notes. (A)
- **Problem:** Writing show notes and timestamps takes a long time after every episode. (A)
- **Current alternative:** Writing by hand, or pasting a transcript into a general AI chat tool and editing the result. (A)
- **Desired outcome:** Publish an episode with accurate notes and timestamps in minutes rather than hours. (A)

Every line is marked A. Maya's job now is to find evidence.

Example 2: Dev and QuoteFlow (a segment with unclear problem)

Dev's first target: "small businesses." He narrowed to "owner-operated residential painting and renovation contractors with one to five employees."

- **Customer:** Owner-operators of small residential painting companies. (A)
- **Problem:** Estimates are slow to produce, which may cost them jobs. (A)

- **Current alternative:** Handwritten quotes, a word processor template, or a spreadsheet. (A)
- **Desired outcome:** Send a professional estimate the same day as the site visit. (A)

Dev notices a risk: he doesn't know if contractors consider this a problem at all. Some may already have a quoting tool, and some may lose no jobs because of speed. He writes "Unknown: do they lose jobs from slow quotes?" at the top of his worksheet. That is a good habit.

One-sentence value proposition

Use this formula as a working draft:

> **We help [specific customer] [achieve desired outcome] without [main pain or current alternative].**

Examples (all hypothetical):

- "ClipNotes helps solo podcasters publish show notes and timestamps in minutes without spending hours after each episode."
- "QuoteFlow helps small painting contractors send a clean estimate the same day without typing it up at night."
- "ReviewReply helps independent coffee shop owners answer online reviews quickly without writing every response from scratch."

Positioning template

Fill this in and keep it somewhere visible:

> For **[customer type]** who **[situation or trigger]**, **[product name]** is a **[category]** that **[key benefit]**. Unlike **[current alternative]**, it **[main difference]**.

How to narrow an overly broad idea

If you can't picture twenty specific people, narrow using one of these dimensions:

- **Role:** "Marketing people" → "freelance social media managers"
- **Size:** "Businesses" → "businesses with 1 to 5 employees"
- **Situation:** "Students" → "graduate students writing a thesis"
- **Tool they use:** "Store owners" → "store owners using a particular e-commerce platform"
- **Frequency:** "People who write" → "people who publish weekly"

Common mistakes and corrections

Mistake	Correction
Choosing a target because it seems large	Choose one you can reach this week; you can expand later.
Describing your product instead of their problem	Rewrite from the customer's perspective, in their words.
Treating your own guess as fact	Mark each line A or E and aim to turn A into E.
Skipping the current alternative	Ask "what do they do today?" It is always something.
Choosing a target you have no way to contact	Add "reachability" to your scoring and weigh it seriously.

Chapter 1 action checklist

- [ ] Listed 8 to 15 possible customer types.
- [ ] Scored them on pain, reachability, ability to pay, and fit.
- [ ] Chose one narrow segment.
- [ ] Wrote the four-part definition and marked each line A or E.
- [ ] Wrote a one-sentence value proposition.
- [ ] Completed the positioning template.
- [ ] Wrote down what I most need to find out.

Chapter 2: Find Your First 20 Qualified Prospects

A **prospect** is a specific person or business that might have the problem your product addresses. A **qualified** prospect is one for whom you have recorded a reason to believe they fit your target and, ideally, evidence that they experience the problem.

The goal here is not a list of random names. It is twenty people you could contact with a message that references something real about their situation.

Two kinds of evidence

Keep these separate in your notes:

- **Fit evidence:** shows the person belongs to your target group. Example: "Hosts a weekly podcast and publishes show notes on their site."

- **Problem evidence:** shows they actually experience the problem. Example: "Posted last week that show notes take them hours."

Fit evidence alone makes someone a possible prospect. Fit plus problem evidence makes them a strong one. Beginners often stop at fit, then wonder why their messages feel generic.

Where to look

Choose two or three places from this list where your segment actually spends time. Don't try all of them.

1. Online communities and forums. Subreddits, niche forums, Discord or Slack communities, and Facebook groups for your segment. Read first, and read the rules before posting anything.

2. Public discussions where people describe problems. Posts that begin with "how do you handle…", "I'm so tired of…", "anyone know a better way to…", or "what do you use for…" are gold. They are people describing their problem in their own words.

3. Professional networks and LinkedIn. Search by role, industry, and keywords. Public posts and profiles tell you what someone does and sometimes what they struggle with.

4. Relevant businesses and their websites. For business-facing products, look at local or niche businesses directly. Their websites, reviews, and public social pages show how they operate. (For QuoteFlow, a contractor's site might show no online quote request form or a very basic one.)

5. Existing competitors and the audiences they serve. If competitors exist, that is useful: it suggests people already pay for this kind of solution. Look at who is publicly discussing, reviewing, or asking questions about those tools, and what they say is missing or frustrating. Treat the people who engage as signals about a market, not as contacts to scrape.

6. Public product directories and founder communities, where appropriate. Some directories and communities have people actively looking for tools in a category. Others are only founders talking to each other, who are rarely your customers unless you sell to founders. Be honest about which one you are in.

Search phrases to start with

Adapt these to your segment. Replace the brackets with your own terms.

- "[task] takes forever"
- "how do you handle [task]"
- "tired of [task]"

- "what do you use for [task]"
- "best way to [task] for [customer type]"
- "[competitor name] alternative"
- "[competitor name] frustrating" or "[competitor name] too expensive"
- "[task] spreadsheet" (people building workarounds)
- "[task] template" (people looking for a shortcut)
- "I wish there was a tool that [outcome]"

Try the same phrases in each platform's own search, and also in a general web search with the platform name added. Save searches that work.

Ethical research, privacy, and community rules

Research is not an excuse to be intrusive. Follow these principles:

1. **Use only publicly shared information,** and use it for the narrow purpose of deciding whether and how to contact someone relevantly.
2. **Read and follow the rules** of every community and platform. Many restrict self-promotion, direct messages to members, or collecting member data. If the rules say no, don't.
3. **Don't scrape or bulk-collect** personal data. Twenty hand-researched prospects is the goal, not twenty thousand names.
4. **Don't dig into private life.** If you find personal details unrelated to the professional problem, don't record or reference them.
5. **Don't pretend to know someone.** Mentioning something they publicly posted is fine. Implying a relationship that doesn't exist is not.
6. **Check the rules for your region and channel,** especially for cold email, which is regulated differently in different places.
7. **Keep your notes secure.** A prospect list contains personal data. Don't share it casually.

Scoring method

Use a simple score to decide whom to contact first. It prioritizes relevance and evidence. It does not predict who will buy, and nothing can do that reliably from a distance.

Criterion	Score	Meaning
Fit	0 to 2	0 = unclear, 1 = probably fits, 2 = clearly fits your segment

Criterion	Score	Meaning
Problem evidence	0 to 3	0 = none, 1 = indirect, 2 = they mentioned a related frustration, 3 = they described this exact problem in detail
Recency	0 to 1	1 if the evidence is from roughly the last few months
Reachability	0 to 1	1 if there is an appropriate, permitted way to contact them
Relevance of your help	0 to 1	1 if you could say something genuinely useful to them

Maximum: 8. Contact the 6 to 8s first. Treat 3 to 5 as "keep watching." Drop anything below 3.

Use scores to choose an order, not to decide someone's worth. A 5 who replies warmly is more informative than a 7 who ignores you.

Prospect research template

Use Appendix B for a full worksheet. Here is what each field means:

Field	What to record	Why it matters
Name or business	Who they are	So you can find them again
Segment	Which target group	Lets you compare segments later
Source	Where you found them (with link)	Proof of where the evidence came from
Fit evidence	Why they match	Prevents random names
Problem evidence	What they said or showed	Powers personalization
Current alternative	What they appear to use	Informs your message and offer
Contact channel	Where it is appropriate to reach them	Respects rules and preferences
Personalization note	One real observation to mention	Keeps messages honest
Score	Using the method above	Orders your outreach
Next action	What you will do and when	Keeps momentum

Worked example: Maya finds and qualifies prospects

(Hypothetical. All names and posts are invented for illustration.)

Step 1: Choose two sources. Maya picks a podcasting subreddit and a podcasting community on a chat platform, both of which allow members to ask for feedback under certain rules. She reads the rules of each and notes that one prohibits unsolicited direct messages and the other allows them if the person has posted a request for help.

Step 2: Search. She searches the subreddit for "show notes" and "timestamps," then sorts by recent.

Step 3: Review results. She finds a post from a hypothetical user, "Jordan," titled something like "How do you write show notes without losing your mind?" Jordan says they run a weekly interview show, edit it alone, and spend a couple of hours on notes every episode.

Step 4: Qualify. Maya checks Jordan's public profile. The show has a website with show notes on every episode, published weekly.

- Fit: 2 (solo, weekly, writes notes)
- Problem evidence: 3 (described the exact problem)
- Recency: 1 (posted recently)

- Reachability: 0 (the community prohibits unsolicited messages, so she should reply publicly if the rules allow)
- Relevance of help: 1
- **Total: 7**

Step 5: Record. She enters Jordan in her worksheet with the link to the post, the quote she wants to reference (a paraphrase, not a copy), and the decision: reply publicly with a useful tip, not a pitch.

Step 6: Contrast with a weak prospect. Another user, "Priya," posts a photo of her new microphone. She fits the segment (a podcaster), but there is no problem evidence at all. Score: 2 + 0 + 1 + 1 + 0 = 4. Maya adds Priya to "keep watching" but doesn't contact her yet. Messaging her about show notes would be guessing.

Step 7: Repeat until she has twenty entries. In this case she finds it takes a few sessions, and some entries come from searching show websites directly: she looks for shows that publish weekly but have sparse or inconsistent notes, which may suggest the problem.

Note what Maya did not do. She did not export a member list, message everyone who mentioned a microphone, or claim she'd "noticed" something she hadn't.

If you can't find twenty

This is useful information. It may mean:

- Your segment is too narrow, so widen one dimension.
- You are looking in the wrong place, so try a different source.
- The problem is rarely discussed publicly. In that case, look at businesses and their websites, or ask in a community whether anyone handles this task.
- The segment may not feel this problem strongly.

Chapter 2 action checklist

- [ ] Chose two or three sources where my segment actually gathers.
- [ ] Read the rules of each community and platform.
- [ ] Ran at least ten search phrases and saved the ones that worked.
- [ ] Created a prospect research worksheet (Appendix B).
- [ ] Recorded fit evidence and problem evidence separately.
- [ ] Scored each prospect.
- [ ] Reached twenty entries, or noted why I couldn't.
- [ ] Chose the top five to contact first.

Chapter 3: Identify Real Customer Pain

Finding a person with a plausible problem is not the same as finding a problem worth solving. This chapter shows you how to judge how much a problem matters before you invest more time.

An interesting idea versus a problem people want solved

People will say "that sounds cool" about nearly anything. A **problem people actively want to solve** looks different. It tends to show up as one or more of:

- **Effort already spent:** they built a spreadsheet, hired someone, or cobbled together several tools.
- **Money already spent:** they pay for a tool, a freelancer, or a service.
- **Repeated complaint:** they bring it up more than once, unprompted.
- **Visible cost:** lost time, lost income, missed deadlines, or stress they can name.
- **Active searching:** they ask others for recommendations or alternatives.

If none of those appear, the problem may be real but low priority. A low-priority problem is a hard thing to sell a solution to.

Step 1: Map the current workflow

Write down, step by step, what the person does today to get the job done. Where you can't see a step, mark it as unknown.

For QuoteFlow, Dev's hypothetical map of a contractor's workflow:

1. Visit the property and take notes (phone notes or paper).
2. Return home or to the truck and calculate materials and labor.
3. Type or write the estimate in a template.
4. Send it by email or text.
5. Wait for a reply.
6. Follow up (or forget to).

Dev now sees at least three places a problem might hide: step 3 (time to write), step 4 (professionalism of the document), and step 6 (follow-up). He doesn't know which one, if any, hurts. Good. He knows what to ask.

Step 2: Find current solutions and workarounds

List everything the prospect uses or could use:

- Dedicated software (competitors)

- General tools used creatively (spreadsheets, documents, chat assistants)
- People (assistants, bookkeepers, freelancers)
- Doing nothing, or doing it manually

A workaround is stronger evidence than a complaint. Complaining is free. Building a spreadsheet takes effort.

Step 3: Look for evidence of urgency, inconvenience, cost, or lost time

Ask yourself of every post or conversation:

- Is there a cost? (Money, time, missed opportunities.)
- Is there a deadline or trigger? (Seasonal rush, new regulation, a bad experience.)
- Do they describe consequences? ("I lost a job because the quote was late.")
- How often does it happen? (Daily problems matter more than annual ones.)

Weak versus stronger evidence

Weaker evidence	Stronger evidence
"That would be nice."	"I currently pay someone to do this."
A like or upvote on a related post	A detailed description of their last attempt to fix it
One person complaining once	Several unrelated people describing the same issue
A complaint about a competitor's price	A switch from one tool to another because of a specific issue
Interest in the idea	Willingness to try it now, share data, or pay
Your friends say it's useful	Strangers in your segment describe the problem unprompted

Evaluating public complaints without jumping to conclusions

A public complaint is a lead, not a conclusion. Before you act on one, consider:

- **Who is complaining?** A vocal minority can look like a crowd.
- **Is it a feature request or a pain?** "I wish it had dark mode" is not a problem you solve with a new product.
- **Is the complaint about price or about value?** People complain about prices of things they use heavily, too.
- **Is it recent?** A two-year-old complaint may be solved.

- **Is it a venting post?** Venting does not always mean they'd pay or switch.

Problem-evidence worksheet

Copy this for each segment.

Question	What I found	Source	Strength (weak / moderate / strong)
What is the current workflow?			
What workarounds do people use?			
What do they pay for today?			
What cost, time, or loss do they describe?			
How often does the problem occur?			
Is there a trigger or deadline?			
How many separate people described this?			
What contradicts my assumption?			

Always fill in the last row. If you can't find any contradicting evidence, you probably haven't looked hard enough.

Hypothetical example: Sam and ReviewReply

(Hypothetical.) Sam searches for coffee shop owners discussing online reviews. He finds:

- Several owners saying replying to reviews is something they "know they should do" but rarely get to.
- One owner saying they started ignoring reviews because angry ones felt personal.
- Nothing about paying anyone to handle it.
- A few owners saying their reviews barely influence customers.

Sam's honest reading: there is some pain (time, emotional weight) but weak evidence of spending or urgency, and some owners contradict the assumption that reviews matter. This is moderate evidence at best. He doesn't abandon the idea. He decides to test in conversations whether any owners treat reviews as important enough to act on, and whether a narrower group, such as owners of shops in competitive areas or with recent complaints, cares more.

Decision process: continue, narrow, or reconsider

After gathering evidence, choose one:

Continue if you find several independent people describing the problem, some effort or spending already directed at it, and a reachable group. Move to conversations (Chapters 4 and 5).

Narrow if the problem appears strongly in one subgroup but weakly elsewhere. Example: Sam finds that owners of busy shops with many reviews feel more pressure than owners of tiny shops. Redefine the segment and repeat Chapter 2.

Reconsider if you find little evidence of pain, little effort or spending, and people already satisfied with simple alternatives. Reconsidering can mean a different segment for the same product, a different problem the product could solve, or a different product altogether. It doesn't mean you failed. It means you found out cheaply.

Write your decision and the reason in one sentence. Revisit it after the conversations in Chapter 5.

Chapter 3 action checklist

- [ ] Mapped the current workflow for my segment, marking unknown steps.
- [ ] Listed current solutions and workarounds.
- [ ] Filled in the problem-evidence worksheet.
- [ ] Classified my evidence as weak or stronger.
- [ ] Recorded evidence that contradicts my assumptions.
- [ ] Chose to continue, narrow, or reconsider, and wrote why.

Chapter 4: Start Conversations Without Spamming

The goal of your first message is not to sell. It is to start a relevant conversation that is useful to the other person.

If selling makes you uncomfortable, that is a useful instinct. It will help you avoid the behaviors that make outreach feel awful: generic pitches, fake familiarity, and pressure.

What spam is, and what it isn't

Spam is not defined by how many messages you send. It is defined by relevance and respect. A message is spam-like when it:

- Is identical to many others.
- Pretends to know the recipient.

- Mentions nothing real about them.
- Asks for something big before offering anything.
- Ignores a "no."

A single, short, honest message to someone with a specific, visible problem is not spam, even if it's unsolicited.

A simple framework for a first message

Use these four parts, in this order:

1. **Real observation:** One specific, true thing about them or their situation.
2. **Why you're writing:** Your honest connection to the topic, in one sentence.
3. **Small, easy ask (or small gift):** Something that takes them under two minutes, or a useful piece of information.
4. **Easy out:** A line that makes "no" comfortable.

Keep it short. Most first messages should be under 100 words.

Choose the right channel

Channel	Best for	Watch out for
Public reply	Someone asked a question or described a problem publicly	Self-promotion rules; reply to help, not to pitch
Direct message	Someone who invited contact or where the platform allows it	Platform restrictions; don't DM people who haven't opened the door if the rules forbid it
Email	Business owners and professionals with a public business address	Regional rules on commercial email; honest subject lines; an unsubscribe or opt-out option where required
Introductions	Warm connections through someone you know	Don't spam your network; ask for introductions only where it genuinely makes sense

Template 1: Relevant public reply

When to use: Someone publicly asked how to solve the problem your product addresses.

Personalize: Their actual situation and what they said they tried.

Example (ClipNotes, hypothetical):

> You mentioned spending a couple of hours on notes for each interview episode. One thing that helped me think about this: separating the "chapter markers" from the "summary" task, since markers can be done while listening and the summary after. If it's useful, I'm also building a tool for this and would love a few people to try it and tell me what's missing. No pressure at all, happy to share a tip list either way.

Mistakes to avoid: Leading with your product. Replying to every post with the same text. Breaking community rules on self-promotion. If the rules forbid mentioning your product, give help only.

Template 2: Personalized direct message

When to use: The platform and community allow messages, and you have a real reason to write.

Personalize: Reference something specific they said or did. Not "I love your content," but "your post last week about…"

Example (QuoteFlow, hypothetical):

> Hi [Name], I saw your company's page and noticed you do interior and exterior repainting. I'm researching how small painting contractors put together estimates after a site visit, because I'm building a tool in this area. Would you be open to answering two or three questions about how you do it today? I'm not selling anything right now, and no worries at all if you're too busy.

Mistakes to avoid: Claiming you've been "following their work." Asking for a call in the first line. Sending the same message to dozens of people with only the name changed.

Template 3: Professional email

When to use: A business owner or professional with a public business email.

Personalize: The business's specific situation, observed from their website or public presence.

Example (ReviewReply, hypothetical):

> **Subject:** Quick question about your review replies
>
> Hi [Name],
>
> I noticed your café has a lot of recent reviews on your public page, and a few don't have replies yet. I'm researching how small café owners handle this, because it looks time-consuming. Could I ask you three short questions, by email or a 10-minute call, about how you deal with reviews?
>
> I'm not selling anything. If this isn't relevant, just let me know and I won't write again.
>
> Thanks, Sam

Mistakes to avoid: Misleading subject lines. Making it sound like a personal relationship. Ignoring regional email rules. Not giving a way to decline.

Template 4: Request for a short problem interview

When to use: After a positive first reply, or when someone has said they have the problem.

Personalize: Refer back to what they said.

Example:

> Thanks for replying. Since you mentioned the notes take you a couple of hours, I'd love to hear how that process works for you from start to finish. Would a 15-minute chat this week be possible? I'll keep it short, and I'm not going to pitch you.

Mistakes to avoid: Asking for an hour. Saying "I'd love to pick your brain" (vague and burdensome). Pitching at the start of the call.

Contacting business owners and creators

For businesses and creators, acknowledge that their time is their income. Be brief, be specific, and make the ask small. A creator who gets hundreds of messages will notice the ones that show you actually watched or read something.

If a creator or business has a published contact method for inquiries, use that rather than hunting for personal channels.

Bad messages rewritten

Bad message 1:

> Hey! I built an AI tool that will revolutionize your podcast workflow. You need to try it. Sign up here: [link]

Why it fails: Generic, claims "revolutionize," pushes a signup, shows no knowledge of the recipient.

Better:

> Hi Jordan, I saw your post about how long show notes take. I'm building a tool aimed at that problem and trying to understand how people actually do it. Would you be willing to tell me how you handle it today? Happy to share what I learn.

Bad message 2:

> Hi [First Name], I came across your company and I'd love to talk about how we can save you 10 hours a week!

Why it fails: An unsupported, specific claim. No evidence of research. Template placeholder energy.

Better:

> Hi Alex, I saw your site says you do quotes within 48 hours of a site visit. I'm trying to learn how small contractors handle estimates and where the slow parts are. Could I ask a few questions? No sales pitch.

Bad message 3:

> I've messaged you twice. Why aren't you replying? This is a great opportunity.

Why it fails: Guilt, pressure, and no value. Never do this.

Better: Send one polite follow-up (Chapter 8), then stop.

Respecting platform rules and "no"

- Read each platform's terms on messaging and automation. Don't use tools that send bulk or automated messages to strangers.
- If someone says no, thank them and stop. Don't argue or "just check once more."
- If someone doesn't reply after one follow-up, move on.
- Keep a "do not contact" list in your tracker.

Chapter 4 action checklist

- [ ] Chose the right channel for each top prospect.
- [ ] Wrote each first message using the four-part framework.
- [ ] Included one real, checkable observation in each message.
- [ ] Kept each message short and gave an easy way out.
- [ ] Checked each community and platform's rules.
- [ ] Did not send identical messages in bulk.
- [ ] Created a do-not-contact list.

Chapter 5: Validate the Problem Before Pitching

When someone agrees to talk, the temptation is to demo immediately. Resist it. The conversation is your best chance to learn what is true about their situation. Once you start pitching, people become polite instead of honest.

Customer discovery is the practice of talking to potential customers to understand their problems, behavior, and priorities, before or alongside selling.

Requesting the conversation

Ask for a small amount of time (10 to 20 minutes), state clearly that you are learning, and make it easy to say no. See Template 4 in Chapter 4 and Appendix D.

Offer a few ways to do it: a call, a video chat, or written answers by message. Some people prefer to write.

The core principle: ask about the past, not the future

People are poor at predicting their own behavior and are generally kind. If you ask "Would you use a tool that does X?" they will often say yes to be agreeable. That tells you almost nothing.

Instead, ask about what actually happened:

- "Tell me about the last time you did [task]."
- "What did you do next?"
- "What was the hardest part?"
- "What have you tried?"
- "What did that cost you, in time or money?"

Past behavior is evidence. Hypothetical enthusiasm is not.

Open-ended and non-leading questions

An **open-ended question** can't be answered with yes or no. A **leading question** hints at the answer you want.

Weak question	Why it's weak	Improved question
"Wouldn't it be great if show notes took one minute?"	Leading and hypothetical	"How do you currently create show notes? Walk me through the last one."
"Would you pay $20 a month for this?"	Hypothetical, premature	"What do you spend on tools or help for this today?"
"Do you find writing estimates frustrating?"	Plants the emotion	"How did you handle your most recent estimate?"
"Don't you think replying to reviews matters?"	Leading	"How do you decide whether to reply to a review?"
"Would you use an AI that does this?"	Hypothetical, tool-focused	"Have you tried using any tools or assistants for this? What happened?"
"What features do you want?"	Customers are poor at designing products	"What's the most annoying part of how you do it today?"

Questions worth asking

Context:

- Tell me about what you do and how [task] fits into your week.
- How often does [task] come up?

Last time:

- Walk me through the last time you did it.
- What happened first? Then what?
- Where did you get stuck or lose time?

Current alternatives:

- What do you use today to handle this?
- What have you tried before? Why did you stop?

Cost and importance:

- What does it cost you when this goes wrong or takes too long?

- How does this rank among other things you're dealing with?

Decision-making:

- Who decides whether to buy a tool for this?
- What would need to be true for you to change how you do this?

Closing:

- Is there anything I should have asked but didn't?
- Is there someone else who deals with this I could talk to?

Interpreting what you hear

What they say	What it likely means	How to respond
"That sounds great!"	Politeness; weak evidence	Ask: "When would you use it?" or "What do you do today?"
"You should add X."	A feature wish; note it, don't assume it's essential	Ask: "What problem would X solve for you?"
"I'd definitely use that."	Hypothetical interest	Ask: "What would you do this week to try it?"
"I already pay for [tool]."	Evidence of spending and a current alternative	Ask: "What do you like and dislike about it?"
"I spent last Sunday doing this and it ruined my day."	Strong problem evidence	Ask about frequency and workarounds
"Let me know when it's ready."	Polite deflection or mild interest	Ask: "What would make it ready for you?"
"Can I try it now? What does it cost?"	Stronger buying signal	See Chapters 6 and 7
"Can I send you my data to test?"	Stronger commitment (effort and trust)	Take it seriously and follow up quickly

Stronger buying signals involve commitment: time, effort, money, data, or introductions. Compliments cost nothing and commit them to nothing.

Recording and synthesizing

Take notes during or right after each conversation. If you want to record, ask permission first and explain why. Within an hour of each conversation, write down:

- Exact phrases they used (these are valuable language for your messaging).
- What they do today, step by step.
- Costs and consequences they mentioned.
- Tools and workarounds.
- Surprises: anything you didn't expect.
- Commitments and next steps.

After three to five conversations, look for patterns: what did several people say independently?

Hypothetical interview

(Entirely invented, for illustration.) Dev interviews a hypothetical painter, "Marcus," who owns a three-person residential painting business.

Dev: Tell me about the last estimate you wrote.

Marcus: Last Tuesday I looked at a two-story exterior. I took notes on my phone in the truck. That night I put it into a spreadsheet and made a PDF.

Dev: How long did that take?

Marcus: About an hour, maybe more. I send maybe six or eight a week in spring.

Dev: What happened after you sent it?

Marcus: I sent it Wednesday. They'd already hired someone by Friday, I found out later.

Dev: How do you think about that?

Marcus: It happens. I can't be everywhere. I hired my niece for a few weeks to help with the paperwork but it was inconsistent.

Dev: Have you looked at any software for it?

Marcus: I tried one a couple years ago. Too complicated. I went back to the spreadsheet.

What can be concluded:

- Marcus describes a recurring, time-consuming task (about an hour per estimate, several per week in busy periods).
- He has spent effort on workarounds (spreadsheet, hiring help).
- He tried software and abandoned it because it was too complicated, which tells Dev that simplicity is likely important.
- He lost at least one job after a delay, though he isn't sure the delay was the cause.

What cannot be concluded:

- That most painters feel this way. This is one person.

- That Marcus would pay for QuoteFlow, or how much.
- That speed is the reason he lost the job.
- That the problem is urgent enough to change his routine.

Dev's next step is more interviews, not a pitch.

Feedback analysis worksheet

After each interview, fill in:

Item	Notes
Who (segment, role, size)	
Date and channel	
Their current workflow	
Their current alternatives	
Costs or consequences they described	
Exact phrases worth keeping	
Evidence strength (weak / moderate / strong)	
Surprises	
Commitments made (time, data, intro, money)	
Follow-up needed	

After five interviews, answer:

1. Which problems came up in at least three conversations?
2. Which current alternatives were mentioned most?
3. Which statements were hypothetical, and which described real past behavior?
4. Should I continue with this segment, narrow it, or change it?

When to show the product

Keep researching if:

- You haven't yet seen a clear, real problem.
- The person hasn't described their current process.
- You'd be showing the product to hear "nice."

Consider showing the product (briefly) if:

- They described a specific problem you can address.
- They asked to see it or asked how it works.
- You've completed your questions and have a specific workflow to illustrate.

Even then, keep the demo small and tied to what they said (Chapter 7).

Chapter 5 action checklist

- [ ] Prepared the interview script (Appendix C).
- [ ] Requested conversations with my top prospects.
- [ ] Practiced asking about past behavior, not future intentions.
- [ ] Took notes within an hour of each conversation.
- [ ] Filled in a feedback analysis worksheet per interview.
- [ ] Looked for patterns after three to five conversations.
- [ ] Decided whether to continue, narrow, or change segment.

Chapter 6: Turn Your App Into a Clear Offer

A product is a collection of capabilities. An **offer** is a specific proposal: for this person, to solve this problem, in this way, at this price, with this next step.

Customers don't buy products. They accept offers. Many first-time builders have a product but no offer.

Features versus outcomes

Feature	Outcome
Generates timestamps from audio	Episodes are published with navigable chapters in minutes
Parses job notes into line items	Estimates go out the same day as the site visit
Drafts replies in the owner's tone	Reviews get answered without the owner writing from scratch

Lead with outcomes. Use features only to explain how the outcome happens.

Who it's for, what problem, how it works

Be able to answer, in one sentence each:

1. **Who is this for?** (Use your segment definition.)

2. **What problem does it solve?** (In their words.)
3. **What does it do about it?** (The shortest honest description.)
4. **How is it different from what they do today?** (Honest, specific.)

Value proposition formula

> **[Product] helps [specific customer] who [situation] to [outcome] by [how it works in plain terms], so they don't have to [current painful alternative].**

Hypothetical example:

> QuoteFlow helps small painting contractors who write estimates after site visits to send a clean, itemized estimate the same day by turning their rough phone notes into a ready-to-send document, so they don't have to retype everything in the evening.

Communicating differentiation honestly

Don't claim to be "the best" or "the only." Claim something specific and checkable:

- "Works from the rough notes you already take, with no new forms to fill."
- "You approve every reply before it posts."
- "Built just for solo podcasters, not for large production teams."

If a competitor does something better, say so. Honesty builds trust faster than inflated claims. Compare against the current alternative: the spreadsheet, the manual process, or an existing tool.

Pricing hypothesis and testing willingness to pay

A **pricing hypothesis** is your best guess about what to charge, held loosely. You'll refine it with evidence.

Simple ways to arrive at one:

1. **Value anchor:** What is the problem costing them? If an estimate takes an hour and they write six a week, what is that time worth to them?
2. **Alternative anchor:** What do they already pay for something similar, including a person's time?
3. **Complexity anchor:** What do comparable tools charge? (Check competitors' public pricing pages.)

Start with a simple structure: one plan and one price. Complicated pricing tiers can wait.

Testing willingness to pay:

- Ask: "What do you spend on this today?" (Chapter 5.)
- State a price directly when you present the offer, and observe the reaction.
- Ask for a commitment: a paid pilot, a deposit, or a prepayment, where appropriate and legal.

Things that do NOT prove willingness to pay:

- Compliments and encouragement.
- Email signups.
- Free usage and free trial activity.
- "I'd pay for that" without a transaction.

These are all useful signals of interest. None of them is the same as someone paying. The real test is whether someone is willing to give money or something comparable in value, such as meaningful time and their own data.

Pilots, trials, paid setup, and early access

Choose the format that fits your product and segment:

Format	What it is	Good when
Free trial	Limited time or usage, no payment	The product's value is quick to see, and you have a clear path to paying
Paid pilot	A short, defined period at a discounted or fixed price	The product requires setup or the buyer needs reassurance
Paid setup	One-time fee to configure for their situation	The product needs customization or data import
Early access	A discounted rate in exchange for feedback	You're still learning and the buyer accepts rough edges

A paid pilot is often more informative than a free trial because paying creates commitment and honest feedback. But it isn't right for everyone. Don't force it where it doesn't fit.

State the terms plainly: what they get, for how long, what it costs, what you expect from them (feedback, a quick call), and what happens afterward.

Avoiding custom features for everyone

When people express interest, they often attach requests. If you build every one, you end up with a product that fits nobody.

A simple rule: Only build a requested feature if:

1. At least three separate prospects in your target segment independently asked for it, **and**
2. It blocks their purchase (not just "would be nice"), **and**
3. It fits the direction you intend for the product.

Otherwise, write it down, thank them, and move on. You can say: "That's useful, I've noted it. It's not something I can promise right now."

Offer-writing worksheet

Complete these lines:

1. **Customer:** _____
2. **Problem (in their words):** _____
3. **Outcome I'm offering:** _____
4. **How it works (one sentence):** _____
5. **What it replaces:** _____
6. **What they get in the offer:** _____
7. **Price or terms:** _____
8. **Time frame:** _____
9. **What I need from them:** _____
10. **What I'm not promising:** _____
11. **Next step (a specific, single action):** _____

Hypothetical offers

ClipNotes (Maya). After several conversations, Maya finds that solo podcasters care most about timestamps and chapter titles, not summaries.

> **Offer:** "For solo podcasters who publish weekly: send me your next three episodes, and ClipNotes will generate timestamps, chapter titles, and a short description for each. You review and edit them. If it saves you time, early access is $X per month for the next three months while I keep improving it. If it doesn't, you've lost nothing."

(The "$X" stands for whatever hypothesis Maya chooses. This book does not claim any price is correct.)

QuoteFlow (Dev). Dev learns that painters value simplicity above all.

> **Offer:** "For small painting contractors: I'll set up QuoteFlow with your company name, rates, and standard line items. For the next two weeks, send me your site-visit notes by text or voice, and you'll get a ready-to-send estimate back in minutes. If you want to continue after two weeks, the monthly fee is $X. Setup is free for the first five contractors."

ReviewReply (Sam). Sam finds that interest is moderate and that busy shops matter most.

> **Offer:** "For café owners with a steady flow of reviews: ReviewReply drafts replies for you to approve in a few clicks. Try it on your last ten unanswered reviews for free. If you want to keep using it, the monthly fee is $X."

Product demo checklist (summary)

A fuller version appears in Appendix E. In brief, a useful demo:

- Is tailored to the prospect's described problem.
- Uses their data or realistic example data.
- Shows the shortest path from problem to outcome.
- Is under fifteen minutes.
- Ends with a clear next step.

Decision framework: what to offer next

Use this table after each batch of conversations:

What you observed	What it suggests	What to offer or do next
Strong problem evidence, they asked to try it	Product-segment fit may exist	Offer a paid pilot or early access
Problem is real but they hesitate on price	Value may be unclear, or price may be off	Clarify the outcome; test a different structure
Interest but no urgency	Problem may be low priority	Narrow to a more urgent subgroup or reconsider
Product doesn't address the real problem	Mismatch	Decide whether to change the product or the segment
Different problem appears repeatedly	New opportunity	Test an offer around that problem

Chapter 6 action checklist

- [ ] Rewrote my product description as outcomes.
- [ ] Wrote a value proposition using the formula.
- [ ] Listed honest differentiators and their limits.
- [ ] Chose an initial pricing hypothesis and its reasoning.
- [ ] Chose an offer format (pilot, trial, setup, early access).
- [ ] Completed the offer-writing worksheet.
- [ ] Set a rule for deciding which feature requests to act on.
- [ ] Prepared a demo using the checklist.

Chapter 7: Demo, Handle Objections, and Ask for the Sale

A demo is not a tour of your product. It is a short, focused demonstration that shows how your product solves the specific problem this person described.

Prepare before the call

1. **Review your notes** on the person: what they said, what they use, what they care about.
2. **Choose the smallest relevant workflow.** One problem, one path, one outcome.
3. **Prepare realistic data.** Ideally their own (with permission); otherwise a close example.
4. **Test everything.** Check your login, internet connection, and example data. A broken demo costs trust.
5. **Decide the ask in advance.** What will you propose at the end?

6. **Set a time limit.** Fifteen to twenty minutes is plenty.

Demo structure

1. **Recap (2 minutes).** Restate their problem in their words. "You mentioned that writing estimates in the evening takes about an hour. Is that still accurate?"
2. **Questions (3 minutes).** Confirm the details that matter. "What do your notes typically look like? What does a finished estimate need to include?"
3. **Show the smallest workflow (5 minutes).** Walk through the path from their input to the outcome. Don't click through every feature. Narrate the benefit, not the buttons.
4. **Check (2 minutes).** "Is this close to what you need? What's missing or wrong?"
5. **Propose the next step (3 minutes).** State the offer plainly (Chapter 6).
6. **Ask (1 minute).** Ask directly for a decision or commitment.

Asking for the sale

Many builders skip this step, then wonder why nothing happens. Asking is not pushy when done honestly. It gives the person a clear decision to make.

Examples of direct, respectful asks:

- "Would you like to start the two-week pilot this week?"
- "The early access price is $X per month. Would you like to sign up today, or is there something you'd need to see first?"
- "Would you be willing to try it with your next three estimates and pay if it saves you time?"

Then stop talking. Let them answer. Silence after an ask is normal.

If they say yes, make the next step easy: send the link, invoice, or setup instructions the same day. If they say no or "not yet," ask what would need to change, and listen.

Handling objections

An **objection** is a reason someone gives for not proceeding. Some are genuine concerns. Some are polite ways to say no. Your job is to understand which, not to overcome every one.

The approach:

1. Listen fully and don't interrupt.
2. Acknowledge the concern honestly.
3. Ask a question to understand it.
4. Respond with facts, or admit a limitation.

5. Check whether that addresses it.

Common objections and suggested responses

Price: "That's too expensive."

> "I understand. Can I ask what you were expecting, or what you compare it to? [Listen.] If the cost is the issue, I can look at whether a smaller plan or a pilot makes sense. If the value isn't clear yet, tell me what you'd need to see."

Genuine if: they can name a number or comparison. *Often a polite no if:* they stay vague and don't engage when you offer options.

Timing: "Not right now, we're too busy."

> "That makes sense. When would be a better time? I'm happy to check back then. Is there something specific that's making it hard right now?"

Genuine if: they give a specific time or reason. *Often a polite no if:* they won't name any time.

Trust: "I don't know you or this tool."

> "That's fair. I'm early, and I'd rather you trust it than guess. What would help? I could do a free trial run on one example, and you don't have to share anything sensitive."

Do not invent testimonials or fake credentials. Offer transparency: how data is handled, what you can and can't promise, and a small, low-risk trial.

Missing features: "It doesn't do X."

> "Thanks, that's helpful. How would you use X? Is it something that would stop you from using it, or something that would be nice to have?"

If it's a deal-breaker for several prospects, take note (see Chapter 6's rule). Don't promise to build it just to close a sale.

Existing alternative: "I already use [tool/spreadsheet] and it works."

> "That's good to hear. What do you like about it? What would you change if you could?"

If they truly have no complaint, it may not be a good fit. Say so.

Genuine objection versus polite rejection

Sign	Genuine objection	Polite rejection
They ask follow-up questions	Yes	No
They propose a specific alternative or timeline	Yes	"Maybe later," no date
They engage when you adjust the offer	Yes	They disengage
They give a reason you can address	Yes	Reasons keep changing
They share information or access	Yes	They stay vague

Neither is a failure. Treat polite rejections as information. Don't assume every objection can be overcome, and don't keep pushing someone who has said no.

When the product is not a fit

Sometimes the honest answer is: this isn't for you. Saying so builds trust and saves both of you time. A quick message works: "It sounds like [product] wouldn't solve your main problem. Thanks for your time. I'd appreciate it if you'd tell me what you'd look for instead."

Avoiding manipulation and false urgency

Don't:

- Claim fake deadlines ("only today!") or fake scarcity ("only two spots left").
- Pressure people to decide on the call.
- Hide the price or terms.
- Exaggerate results or imply guarantees.
- Make up customers or testimonials.
- Make people feel guilty or foolish for hesitating.

Real constraints are fine to state honestly: "I can set up five pilots this month because I'm doing the setup by hand."

Hypothetical dialogue: a demo and an ask

(Invented for illustration.) Maya demos ClipNotes to a hypothetical podcaster, "Jordan."

Maya: You said notes take you a couple of hours per episode, mostly timestamps. Is that still right?

Jordan: Yes, mostly timestamps and picking chapter titles.

Maya: Here's a recent episode of yours I ran, with your permission. This is the output: timestamps, chapter titles, and a short description. What's off?

Jordan: The second chapter title is wrong, and one timestamp is about ten seconds early. But it's pretty close.

Maya: Thank you. I can add a quick edit step. If this saved you most of the time, would you use it on your next three episodes? Early access is $X a month.

Jordan: I'd like to try it on the next episode first. Can I pay after that?

Maya: Yes. Try it on the next episode, then tell me honestly whether you want to continue and I'll send an invoice.

What can be concluded: Jordan engaged specifically, flagged errors, and agreed to a trial. That is a stronger signal than a compliment, but it isn't payment yet.

What cannot be concluded: That Jordan will pay, or that other podcasters will behave the same.

Follow-up message after a demo

> Hi [Name], thanks for taking the time today. Here's a quick recap: you said [their problem in their words], we looked at [the workflow], and you mentioned [one concern or request]. As discussed, the next step is [specific action, dates, and price if relevant]. If you'd like to go ahead, here's [link/instructions]. If it isn't right, no problem. I'd value hearing what would change your mind.

Chapter 7 action checklist

- [ ] Reviewed notes on the prospect before the call.
- [ ] Prepared the smallest relevant workflow and realistic data.
- [ ] Tested everything beforehand.
- [ ] Opened by confirming their problem.
- [ ] Asked a direct, respectful question at the end.
- [ ] Listened to objections and classified them.
- [ ] Did not use false urgency or inflated claims.
- [ ] Sent a follow-up message the same day.

Chapter 8: Follow Up and Learn From Rejection

Most of what happens in customer acquisition happens after the first message. People are busy, distracted, or undecided. Following up well is part of respecting their time while also respecting your own effort.

A simple prospect tracker

You don't need CRM software. A spreadsheet is enough (see Appendix F). Each prospect should have:

- Who they are and where you found them
- What stage they're in
- The date and nature of the last interaction
- The next action and its due date
- Notes on objections or concerns

The rule: Every prospect should always have a next action with a date, or be marked closed. A prospect with no next action is a prospect you will forget.

A simple pipeline

Stage	Meaning
Identified	Researched and recorded
Contacted	First message sent
Replied	They responded
Conversation	You had a discovery conversation
Demo / Offer	They saw the product or an offer
Decision	Awaiting yes or no
Customer	Paid or committed
Closed / Not now	Declined, not a fit, or reconnect later

Counting how many people are at each stage tells you where things are getting stuck.

When to follow up

- **After a first message with no reply:** A single follow-up after several days to a week can be reasonable. Use your judgment based on the channel and the person's situation.

- **After a conversation:** Within 24 hours, send a thank-you and recap.
- **After a demo:** The same day, send the summary and next step.
- **After a promised date:** If they said "check back in two weeks," do exactly that.

There is no universal "right" number of follow-ups. Whether to send another message depends on the context, the person's signals, and the rules of the channel. A good test is: would this message be genuinely useful or relevant to them, or only to me?

Follow-up templates

After no response to a first message (one polite nudge):

> Hi [Name], following up once in case my earlier message got buried. I'm researching how [segment] handles [task]. If you have ten minutes to share how you do it, I'd appreciate it. If not, no worries at all and I won't follow up again.

After a useful conversation:

> Hi [Name], thank you for sharing how you handle [task]. What stood out to me was [one specific thing they said]. As promised, here's [the resource, answer, or intro you mentioned]. If it would help, I'd be glad to show you what I'm working on in a short call. No obligation.

After a demo with no decision:

> Hi [Name], thanks again for looking at [product]. I wanted to check whether you've had a chance to think it over. If it's helpful, I can [specific accommodation: extend the trial, run it on one more example]. If it isn't the right fit, I'd be grateful to know why.

After "reconnect later":

> Hi [Name], you mentioned reaching out around [month/season]. Is now a good time to revisit [topic], or should I check back later?

Responding to silence

Silence is common and is not rejection. People miss messages. Possible causes include busyness, a missed notification, or a lack of interest. You usually can't tell which.

What to do:

1. Send one polite follow-up.

2. If there is still no reply, move them to "Closed / Not now."
3. Record the outcome and move on.
4. Revisit only if their situation changes publicly in a relevant way.

Responding to rejection

When someone says no:

1. Thank them.
2. Ask, once and gently, whether they'd share why. Accept any answer, including none.
3. Record the reason in your tracker.
4. Add them to the do-not-contact list if they asked not to be contacted.

> "Thanks for letting me know. If you have a moment, I'd appreciate hearing what made it a poor fit. Either way, I appreciate your time."

Avoiding repeated contact

- Never contact someone more than once or twice without a reply, unless there's a clear reason that is useful to them.
- Never ask the same question in a different wording.
- Never use a second account or channel to reach someone who declined.
- Honor opt-out requests immediately.

Repeated unwanted contact damages your reputation in small communities, and it is disrespectful.

Identifying patterns

After each week, look across your tracker and ask:

- **Targeting:** Which segments or sources produced the most replies and conversations?
- **Messaging:** Which first messages got responses? Which got none?
- **Positioning:** What words did people use to describe the problem? Are they different from mine?
- **Offer:** At what point did conversations stall? What objections kept appearing?
- **Product:** Did the same missing capability appear repeatedly?

Be careful with small numbers. If three of five people said something, that is a signal worth testing, not a statistic. Don't invent rates or treat a handful of conversations as proof.

Using evidence to improve

If you see	Consider changing
Few replies	The message, the channel, or the quality of personalization
Replies but no conversations	The ask (maybe too big) or the framing
Conversations but weak problem evidence	The segment or the problem you're targeting
Strong problem evidence but no interest in your product	The product's fit with the problem
Interest but no commitment	The offer, the price, or the clarity of value
Commitment but drop-off after	Onboarding, or what the product actually delivers

Change one thing at a time when you can, so you know what caused any difference.

Weekly review worksheet

A full worksheet is in Appendix H. In brief, each week write down:

1. How many prospects did I research, contact, and speak with?
2. Where did my best prospects come from?
3. What objections or concerns appeared?
4. Which assumptions were confirmed or disproved?
5. What am I changing next week, and why?

Chapter 8 action checklist

- [ ] Set up a tracker with the columns in Appendix F.
- [ ] Gave every active prospect a next action and date.
- [ ] Prepared follow-up templates.
- [ ] Created a do-not-contact list.
- [ ] Defined my pipeline stages.
- [ ] Scheduled a weekly review.
- [ ] Wrote down at least one change to try based on evidence.

Chapter 9: Your Seven-Day Customer Acquisition Sprint

This sprint is an execution plan for one week of focused work. It is **not** a promise of revenue. After seven days you will have a defined segment, a researched prospect list, real outreach sent, and evidence from replies. You may or may not have a paying customer. Either way, you will know more than you do now.

Before you start

- Block about one to two hours a day. Some days (like Day 5) may take more if conversations happen.
- Open your tracker (Appendix F) and the worksheets (Appendices A to C).
- Use Appendix G as your daily checklist.

Day 1: Define the Customer and Problem

Objective: Choose one segment and write your assumptions down.

Actions, in order:

1. Complete the customer selection exercise from Chapter 1.
2. Write the four-part definition (customer, problem, alternative, outcome).
3. Mark each line as an assumption (A) or evidence (E).
4. Write your one-sentence value proposition and positioning statement.
5. Choose two or three sources where your segment gathers online.
6. Read each source's rules about posting and messaging.

Output: A completed Customer Definition Worksheet (Appendix A), and a list of sources with notes on their rules.

Checklist:

- [ ] Segment chosen
- [ ] Four-part definition written
- [ ] Assumptions marked
- [ ] Value proposition written
- [ ] Sources and rules noted

Record: The segment, your top three assumptions, and the sources.

If it doesn't go as expected: If you can't choose between segments, pick the one you can reach fastest this week. If you can't define the problem, spend time reading public discussions in the segment and come back.

Day 2: Research and Qualify Prospects

Objective: Find evidence of the problem and begin building your list.

Actions, in order:

1. Run at least ten search phrases from Chapter 2 across your chosen sources.
2. Open each promising result and read the post or page fully.
3. Record fit evidence and problem evidence separately.
4. Score each prospect using the method in Chapter 2.
5. Note the appropriate contact channel and any rules that apply.
6. Begin the problem-evidence worksheet (Chapter 3).

Output: At least ten researched prospects with sources and scores, and a first draft of the problem-evidence worksheet.

Checklist:

- [ ] Ten or more searches run
- [ ] Fit and problem evidence recorded separately
- [ ] Prospects scored
- [ ] Contact rules noted
- [ ] Contradicting evidence noted

Record: Which searches and sources worked best, and what surprised you.

If it doesn't go as expected: If you can't find problem evidence, try different phrases, a different source, or a slightly different segment. If problem evidence is truly rare, that is a finding.

Day 3: Build a List of 20 Relevant Prospects

Objective: Reach twenty qualified prospects, ranked by score.

Actions, in order:

1. Continue research until you have twenty entries.
2. Check each entry for source links, evidence, and a personalization note.
3. Remove anyone who doesn't meet the minimum score or whom you can't contact appropriately.
4. Rank by score. Mark the top ten as "contact first."
5. For each top-ten prospect, write one real observation you could reference.
6. Draft your first message for each, using the framework in Chapter 4.

Output: A ranked list of twenty prospects, and drafted messages for the top ten.

Checklist:

- [ ] Twenty prospects recorded
- [ ] Each has a source and evidence
- [ ] Top ten chosen
- [ ] Ten personalized drafts written (no copy-paste)

Record: Final prospect count, average score, and the channels you'll use.

If it doesn't go as expected: If you can't reach twenty, widen one dimension of your segment, or accept a smaller list and note why.

Day 4: Begin Personalized Outreach and Relevant Participation

Objective: Send real messages and join relevant discussions helpfully.

Actions, in order:

1. Re-read each message to make sure the observation is true and the tone is respectful.
2. Send messages to your top five to ten prospects, through channels that permit it.
3. Reply helpfully to two or three relevant public discussions (where rules allow), without pitching.
4. Log each message in the tracker with date, channel, and what you said.
5. Set a follow-up date for each.

Output: Five to ten personalized messages sent and two or three helpful public replies.

Checklist:

- [ ] Rules re-checked for each channel
- [ ] Each message personalized
- [ ] No bulk or identical messages
- [ ] Tracker updated
- [ ] Follow-up dates set

Record: What you sent, to whom, and when.

If it doesn't go as expected: If you feel stuck about sending, start with one message. If you realize a message isn't truly personalized, rewrite it. Don't send it.

Day 5: Conduct Discovery Conversations and Learn From Replies

Objective: Talk with whoever replied, and learn.

Actions, in order:

1. Respond to each reply promptly and warmly.

2. Schedule conversations, or conduct them in writing.
3. Use the interview script (Appendix C). Ask about past behavior.
4. Take notes and complete a feedback analysis worksheet after each conversation.
5. Send thank-you messages.
6. Send the next batch of messages if you didn't use all of the top ten.

Output: Notes from every conversation you held, and updated tracker entries.

Checklist:

- [ ] Replies answered
- [ ] Conversations completed or scheduled
- [ ] Worksheets completed
- [ ] Thank-you messages sent
- [ ] Next outreach batch sent

Record: Exact phrases used, workflows described, objections, and surprises.

If it doesn't go as expected: If nobody replies, that is information, not failure. Re-read your messages for genericness, check the fit of your list, and send a second batch with a revised approach. Consider whether the channel is wrong. If you do get a reply but they decline, ask once what you should understand.

Day 6: Improve the Offer and Demonstrate the Product Where Appropriate

Objective: Turn what you learned into an offer, and show it where it makes sense.

Actions, in order:

1. Review all notes and look for patterns.
2. Revise your segment definition, value proposition, and messaging.
3. Complete the offer-writing worksheet (Chapter 6) and write your pricing hypothesis.
4. For prospects who described a clear problem, prepare a tailored demo (Appendix E).
5. Offer a short demo or pilot to those prospects.
6. Run any demos that are booked, and ask directly for next steps.

Output: A revised offer, and at least one demo offered (or conducted, if someone agrees).

Checklist:

- [ ] Patterns identified
- [ ] Offer written
- [ ] Price or terms chosen
- [ ] Demo prepared for relevant prospects

- [ ] Direct ask prepared

Record: Which offer you made, to whom, and their response.

If it doesn't go as expected: If nobody wants a demo, don't force it. Revisit the problem evidence. Maybe the problem isn't urgent, or your product doesn't match what people described. If someone does ask for a feature, apply the rule from Chapter 6.

Day 7: Review Evidence and Decide the Next Experiment

Objective: Learn from the week and plan what comes next.

Actions, in order:

1. Update every prospect's status in the tracker.
2. Count: prospects researched, contacted, replied, spoken with, offered, and committed.
3. Fill in the weekly review (Appendix H).
4. Review each assumption from Day 1. Which were confirmed? Which were disproved?
5. Decide: continue with this segment, narrow it, or change it.
6. Choose **one** experiment for next week and write its question and measure.
7. Send follow-ups that are due.

Output: A completed weekly review and a written plan for week two.

Checklist:

- [ ] Tracker updated
- [ ] Numbers counted
- [ ] Assumptions reviewed
- [ ] Decision made
- [ ] One experiment chosen
- [ ] Due follow-ups sent

Record: What you learned and what you will change.

If it doesn't go as expected: If you have little data, the experiment is to get more: extend outreach, change the channel, or widen the segment. If you have strong signals, ask for commitment and move toward a paid pilot.

Remember what this is

Seven days is a sprint to generate evidence and begin conversations. Some people will find a buyer in this time. Many will not, and that is normal. A week with zero customers but clear learning is a successful week.

How to repeat the process over subsequent weeks

Run the loop weekly:

1. **Monday:** Review last week and pick one experiment.
2. **Tuesday and Wednesday:** Research and add new prospects (aim for five to ten a week).
3. **Thursday:** Send personalized outreach and follow-ups.
4. **Friday:** Hold conversations and demos.
5. **End of week:** Weekly review (Appendix H).

Change one variable at a time: the segment, the channel, the message, the offer, or the price. Record what you changed, so you can see what each change did.

If, after several weeks and dozens of well-targeted conversations, you consistently see weak problem evidence, consider whether you need a different segment, a different problem, or a different product. That is a normal part of the process, not the end of it.

Conclusion: Build Less on Assumptions, Learn More From Buyers

If you remember only a few ideas from this book, make them these.

A working product is not evidence of demand. Only people with the problem can tell you whether it matters to them.

Be specific. A narrow customer, a clear problem, and a concrete offer give you something to say and someone to say it to.

Separate fit from evidence. A person can match your target and still not have the problem. Look for the second.

Ask about the past. What people did is more reliable than what they say they would do.

Be respectful. Personalized, honest, short messages outperform generic ones, and they keep your reputation intact. Stop when someone says no.

Treat compliments, signups, and free usage as signals of interest, not proof of willingness to pay. Ask for a real commitment, honestly and respectfully.

Silence and rejection are normal. They tell you something. Record them and adjust.

Don't build for every request. Build when several people in your segment need something that blocks their purchase.

Keep going in small loops. One week of focused effort, a review, and a new experiment will teach you more than another month of building alone.

Your next-action checklist

- [ ] Choose one narrow customer segment today.
- [ ] Write your four-part definition and mark each line A or E.
- [ ] Find five prospects with evidence of the problem.
- [ ] Draft one honest, personalized message.
- [ ] Send it.
- [ ] Set up your tracker.
- [ ] Block time for your first seven-day sprint.

You built the product. Now go and learn who needs it.

Appendix A: Customer Definition Worksheet

Fill in one worksheet per segment. Mark each entry **A** (assumption) or **E** (evidence), and note the source of any evidence.

Item	Your answer	A or E	Source (if E)
Segment name			
Who they are (role, size, situation)			
Where they gather online			
The problem, in their words			
How often it occurs			
Cost or consequence			
Current alternative			
What they dislike about it			
Desired outcome			
Who decides and pays			
What they currently spend			
Why now (trigger or urgency)			

One-sentence value proposition:

> We help _____ _____ without _____.

Positioning statement:

> For _____ who _____, _____ is a _____ that _____. Unlike _____, it _____.

Top three assumptions to test:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

What would change my mind about this segment:

(Write your answer here.)

Appendix B: Prospect Research Worksheet

Use one row per prospect. Add rows as needed. Keep personal data secure and use it only for appropriate, relevant outreach.

Field	What to enter	Entry
Name or business	Who they are	
Segment	Which group from Appendix A	
Source and link	Where you found them	
Date found	When	
Fit evidence	Why they match the segment	
Problem evidence	What they said or showed (paraphrase; note the date)	
Evidence strength	None / Indirect / Related / Detailed (0 to 3)	
Current alternative	What they appear to use	
Potential problem	What you think they struggle with (mark as assumption)	
Personalization note	One true observation to reference	
Contact channel	Where it's appropriate and permitted	
Rules to follow	Platform or community restrictions	

Field	What to enter	Entry
Score	Fit (0–2) + Evidence (0–3) + Recency (0–1) + Reachability (0–1) + Relevance (0–1)	
Priority	Contact first / Keep watching / Drop	
Next action and date	What and when	

Scoring reminder: The score prioritizes outreach order. It does not predict purchasing.

Appendix C: Customer Discovery Interview Script

Time: 15 to 20 minutes. **Goal:** Learn, not sell.

Before you begin

- Review your notes on the person.
- Have your notes template ready.
- If you want to record, ask permission first.

1. Opening (2 minutes)

> "Thanks for making time. To set expectations: I'm trying to understand how people in [segment] handle [task]. I'm not selling anything today. There are no right or wrong answers, and I'm mostly here to listen. Is it okay if I take notes?"

2. Context (3 minutes)

- "Tell me a bit about what you do and how [task] fits into your work."
- "How often do you do [task]?"

Follow-ups: "Can you say more about that?" "What does a typical week look like?"

3. The last time (5 to 7 minutes)

- "Tell me about the last time you did [task]. Walk me through it from the start."
- "What happened first? What next?"
- "Where did you get stuck or spend more time than you wanted?"
- "What did you do about it?"

Follow-ups: "What happened then?" "How did you decide that?" "What did that cost you?"

4. Current alternatives (3 minutes)

- "What do you use today to handle this?"
- "What have you tried before? Why did you stop?"
- "What do you like or dislike about your current approach?"
- "Have you paid for anything to help with this?"

5. Importance and cost (2 minutes)

- "How important is it compared with your other priorities?"
- "What happens when this goes wrong, or doesn't get done?"
- "Has it ever cost you time, money, or an opportunity?"

6. Decision-making (1 minute)

- "Who decides whether to adopt a tool for this?"
- "What would have to be true for you to change how you do it?"

7. Closing (2 minutes)

- "Is there anything I should have asked but didn't?"
- "Do you know anyone else who deals with this?"
- "Would it be okay to follow up if I have more questions?"

> "Thank you. This was really helpful. I'll send a short note with what I learned."

Notes section

Item	Notes
Name / segment / date	
Current workflow	
Tools and workarounds	
Costs and consequences	
Exact phrases	
Past behavior (what they actually did)	
Hypothetical statements (flag these)	
Commitments made	

Item	Notes
Surprises	
Evidence strength	
Follow-up needed	

Appendix D: Outreach Template Library

How to use these templates: They are starting points. Before sending any message, replace every bracket with a real, specific detail, and rewrite any line that doesn't sound like you. **Do not send identical messages in bulk.** Check platform and community rules each time. If a person declines or does not respond to a follow-up, stop.

1. Relevant public reply

Use when: Someone publicly asked for help with a problem you understand.

Template:

> Hi [Name], on [specific thing they asked or described]: one approach that may help is [genuinely useful tip or resource]. I've been looking into this area myself, so I'd be curious how it works out. If it would be useful, I'm happy to share what else I've learned.

Personalize: Reference their actual question. Make the tip useful on its own. Mention your product only if the community's rules allow it and it's relevant. Even then, keep it secondary.

Avoid: Leading with a link, replying with the same text to multiple posts, or ignoring community rules.

2. Personalized professional DM

Use when: Direct messages are allowed and you have a real reason to write.

Template:

> Hi [Name], I saw [specific, true observation, e.g., your post about X / your page mentions Y]. I'm researching how [segment] handles [task], and I'm building something in this area. Would you be open to sharing how you do it today? Just a few questions, and no pitch. No problem at all if you're busy.

Personalize: The observation must be real and recent. Use their language for the task.

Avoid: Flattery that isn't specific, implying a relationship, and asking for a call in the first line.

3. Personalized business email

Use when: You have a publicly listed business email and a business-relevant reason to write.

Template:

> **Subject:** [Specific, honest subject, e.g., "Question about how you handle estimates"]
>
> Hi [Name],
>
> I noticed [specific observation from their website or public page]. I'm researching how [type of business] handles [task], because it looks time-consuming. Would you be willing to answer three short questions by email or a 10-minute call?
>
> I'm not selling anything right now. If this isn't relevant, just tell me and I won't write again.
>
> Thanks, [Your name] [Your product or role, honestly]

Personalize: The observation, the task, and the time you're asking for. Include any sender identification and opt-out information your region requires.

Avoid: Misleading subject lines, false familiarity, and bulk sending.

4. Request for a short research conversation

Use when: Someone replied positively, or has publicly described the problem.

Template:

> Thanks for getting back to me. Since you mentioned [thing they said], I'd love to hear how that works for you from start to finish. Would 15 minutes sometime this week work? I can also take written answers if you prefer. I won't pitch you.

Personalize: Refer to something specific they said. Offer two or three time options or a written alternative.

Avoid: Asking for an hour, using "pick your brain," and pitching on the call.

5. Follow-up after no response

Use when: You sent one message, a few days have passed, and there's been no reply.

Template:

> Hi [Name], I'm following up once in case my earlier note got buried. I'm trying to understand how [segment] handles [task]. If you have ten minutes to share how you do it, I'd be grateful. If not, no worries, and I won't follow up again.

Personalize: Add something new and relevant if you have it (a useful resource, a relevant observation).

Avoid: Guilt ("I haven't heard from you"), pressure, or a third message.

6. Follow-up after a useful conversation

Use when: Within 24 hours of a discovery conversation.

Template:

> Hi [Name], thank you for sharing how you handle [task]. What stood out to me was [one specific, accurate point they made]. [Deliver anything you promised: a resource, an intro, an answer.] If it would be useful, I'd be happy to show you what I'm working on in a short call, with no obligation. And if you know anyone else who deals with this, I'd appreciate an introduction.

Personalize: Paraphrase their idea accurately. Deliver anything you promised.

Avoid: Pitching hard, misrepresenting what they said, or asking for an introduction before you've shown value.

7. Invitation to see a relevant demo

Use when: They described a specific problem your product addresses.

Template:

> Hi [Name], you mentioned [problem in their words]. I've built something that handles part of that: [one-sentence description]. Would you be open to a 15-minute walkthrough using [their example or realistic data]? You can tell me what's missing or wrong. Not looking for a commitment, just honest feedback.

Personalize: Use their words for the problem. Offer to use their own example if they're comfortable.

Avoid: Overpromising, describing every feature, or making the demo feel obligatory.

8. Clear, respectful paid offer

Use when: After a demo or strong conversation where they showed real interest.

Template:

> Hi [Name], based on what you told me about [problem] and what we saw in the demo, here's a proposal:
>
> - **What you get:** [specific outcome and deliverables]
> - **Time frame:** [dates or duration]
> - **Price:** $[amount] [one-time / per month]
> - **What I'd need from you:** [feedback, data, a short check-in]
> - **What I'm not promising:** [limits, honestly stated]
>
> If this works for you, [specific next step, e.g., "reply yes and I'll send an invoice"]. If it's not the right fit or the timing is off, that's completely fine. I'd just appreciate knowing what would change that.

Personalize: Tie every line to what they said. Be clear about what you can and can't deliver.

Avoid: Fake deadlines, vague terms, hidden costs, or pressure.

Appendix E: Product Demo Checklist

Preparation

- [ ] Reviewed notes and the problem the person described.
- [ ] Chose the smallest relevant workflow.
- [ ] Prepared realistic or their own data (with permission).
- [ ] Tested login, internet, and sample data.
- [ ] Prepared a backup (screenshots or a short recording) in case something fails.
- [ ] Decided the ask and the offer in advance.
- [ ] Set a time limit (15 to 20 minutes).

Buyer context

- [ ] Know their role, segment, and current process.
- [ ] Know their current alternative.

- [ ] Know who decides and pays.
- [ ] Know their likely concerns (price, trust, switching effort).

Demonstration

- [ ] Opened by confirming their problem in their words.
- [ ] Showed the path from their input to the outcome.
- [ ] Narrated benefits, not just buttons.
- [ ] Avoided unrelated features.
- [ ] Was honest about limitations and rough edges.

Questions

- [ ] Asked "Is this close to what you need?"
- [ ] Asked "What's missing or wrong?"
- [ ] Asked "How would this fit into your week?"
- [ ] Asked about anything that would stop them using it.

Offer

- [ ] Stated the offer plainly: what, how long, price, what I need.
- [ ] Stated limits and what is not promised.
- [ ] Asked directly for a decision or commitment.
- [ ] Stayed quiet and listened after asking.

Next steps

- [ ] Agreed a specific next step and date.
- [ ] Sent a recap and follow-up the same day.
- [ ] Logged objections and feature requests in the tracker.
- [ ] Updated the prospect's stage and next action.

Appendix F: Customer Acquisition Tracker Template

Create a spreadsheet with one row per prospect and the following columns.

Columns

Column	What it means
Prospect	Name or business
Customer segment	Which segment from Appendix A
Source	Where you found them (with link)
Evidence	Fit and problem evidence, briefly
Contact channel	Public reply, DM, email, or introduction
Outreach date	Date of first message
Response	None / Declined / Replied / Positive / Other
Conversation notes	Key points from any conversation
Objections	Reasons given for hesitation or no
Next action	What you will do next
Follow-up date	When you will do it
Outcome	Open / Customer / Not a fit / Declined / Not now / Do not contact

Optional extra columns: **Score**, **Stage** (from Chapter 8), **Offer made**, **Price discussed**.

Example rows (all hypothetical)

Prospect	Segment	Source	Evidence	Channel	Outreach date	Response	Conversation notes	Objections	Next action	Follow-up date	Outcome
"Jordan" (fictional podcaster)	Solo weekly podcasters	Podcasting forum post	Posted that notes take hours; publishes weekly	Public reply	Mar 3	Replied	Spends 2 hrs on timestamps; tried a general chat tool and found it inaccurate	Worries about accuracy	Offer to test on one episode	Mar 10	Open
"Marcus" (fictional painter)	Small painting contractors	Company website	Website lists no online quote form	Email	Mar 4	Positive	Spends about an hour per estimate; tried software and found it too complex	Complexity	Demo with his own notes	Mar 11	Open
"Café Alba" (fictional café)	Independent cafés	Public review page	Many recent reviews, several unanswered	Email	Mar 5	None			Send one follow-up	Mar 12	Open

Prospect	Segment	Source	Evidence	Channel	Outreach date	Response	Conversation notes	Objections	Next action	Follow-up date	Outcome
"Priya" (fictional podcaster)	Solo weekly podcasters	Community introductions	Recently launched a show; no problem evidence	None yet					Keep watching	Mar 20	Open
"Lena" (fictional café owner)	Independent cafés	Direct referral	Said reviews feel stressful	Email	Mar 5	Declined	Does not consider reviews important	Low priority	Thank and close		Not a fit

How to use the tracker

1. **Add a row** as soon as you qualify a prospect.
2. **Update the row** within an hour of any interaction.
3. **Always fill in Next action and Follow-up date,** or mark the outcome as closed.
4. **Sort by Follow-up date** each morning and handle what is due.
5. **Never contact** anyone marked "Do not contact."
6. **Review weekly:** count by response and outcome, and read the Objections column for patterns.
7. **Protect the data.** It contains personal information. Don't share it casually, and delete what you no longer need.

Appendix G: Seven-Day Sprint Checklist

Print this page. Tick items as you go and write short notes.

Day 1: Define the Customer and Problem

- [ ] Completed the customer selection exercise
- [ ] Wrote the four-part definition (A/E marked)
- [ ] Wrote value proposition and positioning statement
- [ ] Chose two or three sources and read their rules

Observations: _____

Lessons learned: _____

Day 2: Research and Qualify Prospects

- [ ] Ran 10+ searches
- [ ] Recorded fit and problem evidence separately
- [ ] Scored prospects
- [ ] Noted contact rules

Observations: _____

Lessons learned: _____

Day 3: Build a List of 20 Relevant Prospects

- [ ] Reached twenty prospects (or noted why not)
- [ ] Ranked by score
- [ ] Drafted ten personalized messages

Observations: _____

Lessons learned: _____

Day 4: Begin Outreach and Participation

- [ ] Sent 5 to 10 personalized messages
- [ ] Posted 2 to 3 helpful public replies (where allowed)
- [ ] Logged everything in the tracker
- [ ] Set follow-up dates

Observations: _____

Lessons learned: _____

Day 5: Discovery Conversations

- [ ] Replied to all responses
- [ ] Held or scheduled conversations
- [ ] Filled in feedback worksheets
- [ ] Sent thank-you messages

Observations: _____

Lessons learned: _____

Day 6: Improve the Offer and Demo

- [ ] Reviewed patterns
- [ ] Wrote the offer and pricing hypothesis
- [ ] Prepared a tailored demo
- [ ] Made offers or demos where appropriate

Observations: _____

Lessons learned: _____

Day 7: Review and Decide

- [ ] Updated tracker
- [ ] Counted stages
- [ ] Completed weekly review
- [ ] Chose next experiment
- [ ] Sent due follow-ups

Observations: _____

Lessons learned: _____

Appendix H: Weekly Review

Complete once per week. Be honest. The point is learning, not performance.

Week of: _____ **Segment:** _____

1. The numbers

Measure	This week	Last week
Prospects researched		
Prospects contacted		
Replies		
Conversations held		
Demos or offers		
Commitments or customers		
Declined or closed		

2. What did I learn?

- Most important thing I learned about the customer: _____
- Most important thing I learned about the problem: _____
- Most important thing I learned about my messaging: _____
- Something that surprised me: _____

3. Where did prospects come from?

Source	Prospects found	Replies	Conversations

Which source produced the best conversations, not just the most names?

_____

4. What objections or concerns appeared?

Objection	How many times	Genuine or polite no?	Can I address it?

5. Which assumptions changed?

Assumption	Confirmed / Disproved / Still unknown	Evidence

6. Decision

- [ ] Continue with this segment
- [ ] Narrow the segment (how: _____)
- [ ] Change the segment or problem (to: _____)
- [ ] Change the offer or price (how: _____)

Reason, in one sentence: _____

7. Next experiment

- **Question I'm trying to answer:** _____
- **What I will change (one thing):** _____
- **How I will measure it:** _____
- **Date I'll review it:** _____

8. Housekeeping

- [ ] Follow-ups due this week sent

- [ ] Do-not-contact list updated
- [ ] Notes and tracker saved securely